are pitted against each other (Rajesh Khanna and Amitabh in *Namak Haraam*, for example); or a tennis contest that offers similar variety (Federer versus Nadal). Politics is no different—conflicting chemistries make for a great election battle.

Sure, there were other subplots playing right through this election—the sudden rise of the Aam Aadmi Party and its doughty leader Arvind Kejriwal; the power plays of regional supremos like Mamata, Naveen Patnaik and Jayalalithaa; the break-up of Andhra Pradesh; the antics of feisty caste leaders of the north; the Nitish Kumar ideological challenge. But these were sideshows—the principal narrative remained Modi versus Rahul.

Many political experts reject the idea that a parliamentary-style democracy is actually presidential in nature. A senior Congress leader accused me on a television show of failing to understand the logic of an Indian election. 'Five hundred and forty-three constituencies and you are obsessing about two individuals,' was his angry comment. Truth is, that's how Indian general elections have always played out. The 1952 election in the end was about the overwhelming charisma of Jawaharlal Nehru. In the 1970s, it was Indira Gandhi's dominant image that set the terms of the political debate. In 1984, Rajiv Gandhi offered himself as the fresh-faced hope for the future. In 1989, it was V.P. Singh who was projected as 'Mr Clean'. In the 1990s, the BJP coined the slogan '*Abki Baari Atal Bihari*'. Why, even the silent bureaucrat-politician Dr Manmohan Singh was transformed into 'Singh is King' ahead of the 2009 elections.

The 2014 election was, in the end, about the '*chhappan* inch *kee chhaati*' machismo of the politician from Vadnagar in Gujarat. To quote right-wing columnist Swapan Dasgupta: 'For some he was a modern-day Chhatrapati Shivaji who would finally make Hindus come into their own; to others he was the poor boy next door who had made it big in the ugly and cruel world of Delhi, and to still yet others he was the great liberator of the economy from sloth and socialist incompetence. What united these divergent strands was the belief that his victory would usher in the proverbial happy days.'